



Netflix pulls out of Cannes

Upon Cannes' insistence on competing titles receiving theatrical releases, Netflix pulled out and refused to change their strategy. <https://digit.in/netflix>



Suicide machine unveiled

Euthanasia advocate, Philip Nitschke created the suicide machine named 'Sarco' and believes that suicide is a human right. <https://digit.in/smachine>

Faking it

India's ecommerce platforms need to be held accountable for counterfeits

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he crores spent during each online sale event are testament to how accustomed we've become to making

purchases on e-commerce platforms. We might have become a bit too gullible in our trust towards these platforms, as was evident from the allegations of fake products on Flipkart, Amazon and Shopclues.

After American footwear company Skechers dragged Flipkart and four of its sellers to court over selling fake ripoffs of its products back in December 2017, multiple reports and investigations revealed this is nothing new. One report claimed that almost 60 percent of all sports goods sold online are fake. Brands such as Mont Blanc and L'oreal have taken action against people selling fake products. With such persistent crackdown on fakes on ecommerce platforms, you would think that things would start to change somewhere down the line, right?

Check out this story on Flipkart's 'Stories' platform about fake products: <https://digit.in/FlipFake>. The carefully crafted piece, after elaborately establishing that the onus of identifying fakes on the platform lies with the customer, goes on to declare that "If a product is found to be a fake, the entire listing is immediately taken down along with the entire portfolio of the seller."

The four Flipkart sellers in the Skechers case were Retail Net, Tech Connect, Unichem Logistics and Marco Wagon. Not only can you still find RetailNet (albeit without the space) on the platform selling branded sports shoes, Tech Connect Retail, backed by Airtel CEO Sanjay Kapoor, saw its revenue soar from ₹1.3cr to ₹2,485cr in the year 2017. These sellers are also linked to Flipkart-owned platforms like Myntra and Jabong.

There's no particular way to easily find a seller on Flipkart. You cannot filter by seller in your searches (which you can do on Amazon). We went through the seller onboarding site – there is literally no mention of any-



thing pertaining to sale of fake products and the penalties that a seller will face if they're found guilty of the same. You would think that a platform that claims to have a 'zero-tolerance' policy for fake products would declare the same to its potential sellers upfront. It is probably hidden in some corner on some agreement that the seller is going to sign, most likely without reading.

You would think the Flipkart case was an anomaly, but nothing could be further from the truth. A report from News18, mentioned earlier in the story, was created after an investigation showed that 60 percent of sporting

goods and 40 percent of apparel sold online are counterfeit in some manner or the other. When contacted, all firms involved, Flipkart along with Shopclues and Snapdeal reiterated their 'strict policies' against counterfeit products. Even Amazon issued a statement about no tolerance for fakes on their platform, in the aftermath of the Skechers case, even though they were not a part of the legal proceedings.

This brings us to an important question – are these paper-only policies enough? Would any other industry be allowed to thrive despite a lackadaisical attitude towards their customers being duped? It's not like there's no solution. Alibaba's international e-commerce platform, Tmall Global recently implemented a blockchain solution to bring about a global tracing system that traces the entire origins of imported goods to ensure that fake products do not make it onto the platform. If you think this was easy because of Alibaba's scale, this system, called "Traceability for TMG", is set to be implemented globally across 63 countries and regions, covering 3,700 types of goods and 14,500 international brands.

Jointly participating in this system are various governments, embassies, business associations, and big international brands from countries

around the world including the UK, US, Japan, Korea, and Australia. On the other hand, Flipkart and other Indian sellers need to do this just for one nation, with one government and no embassies, in a country that is well aware and capable of working with technologies such as blockchain. In a market environment where there is an endless stream of competitive sales, it is important and essential for ecommerce sites to check fakes. There is an urgent need to make these e-commerce platforms answerable for their conspicuously missing effort in this direction. 